

Master 08 — Addendum A

SMS Engine vs SMSC — scope clarification

Companion to: Master 08 — Developer RFP / Intervention Test Build Specification.

Added: 22 July 2026. **Status:** DRAFT — new addendum, does not alter or replace Master 08's existing content or review-note sign-off states.

Purpose: Prevent supplier scope confusion between an application-layer "SMS Engine" (in scope, to be built) and a carrier-grade "SMSC" (out of scope, not to be built).

In one line: Master 08's non-negotiable "SMS Engine designed properly from the start" means an application layer that integrates with a third-party SMS gateway/aggregator provider — it does not mean building carrier-grade telecom infrastructure.

Why this needs saying explicitly

An SMSC (Short Message Service Centre) is the store-and-forward infrastructure that mobile network operators themselves run, with direct interconnects into every UK mobile network. Building one is equivalent to becoming a telecoms carrier or aggregator — Ofcom-level obligations, direct commercial agreements with mobile networks, carrier-grade redundancy. That is wildly disproportionate to a bounded intervention test for up to 50 adults, and it is not what this RFP is asking a supplier to price.

What suppliers should actually price and build

	SMS Engine (in scope)	SMSC (out of scope)
What it is	Application layer inside the OTOS build	Carrier-grade telecom infrastructure
What it does	Sends partner-approved templated messages via a chosen aggregator's API; receives inbound replies/opt-outs via webhook; captures delivery receipts; handles retries, quiet-hours and rate limits; logs every event as MessageEvent / SmsDeliveryReceipt on the Thread	Direct SS7/SIGTRAN interconnects with mobile networks; carrier-level message routing across the whole UK mobile estate
Who already provides this	OTOS's own developer, calling an existing aggregator	Existing UK-hosted SMS aggregators (e.g. Twilio, MessageBird, Sinch, Esendex) — already built, already carrier-connected
Capacity implication	Effectively unlimited for this test's purposes — any reasonable aggregator handles far more volume than a 50-person cohort will generate	Not applicable — OTOS should not be pricing or building this

What stays under OTOS's control regardless of provider choice

- Message content — every template is partner-approved and lives in OTOS's own system; the aggregator only moves the message, it never decides content.

- The non-clinical wording rule — enforced by OTOS before anything is sent, not by the aggregator.
- The audit trail — every MessageEvent, SmsDeliveryReceipt, reply, silence and opt-out is recorded in OTOS's own database, not the aggregator's.

Provider choice affects transport only. It does not affect security, content control, or the non-clinical boundary — those remain fully owned by OTOS's own build regardless of which aggregator is selected.

Interaction frequency — a design and cost decision, not a technical ceiling

Because aggregator capacity is not the constraint, the number of touches per participant per day/week (see also the [Partner Interaction Close-up](#) diagram in the Appendix v2) is a decision about engagement design and message cost, not a decision about what the system can carry. Suppliers should be asked to quote based on an assumed cadence (to be confirmed by Dean) rather than asked to size for a technical limit.

Master 08 Addendum A — 22 July 2026. Read alongside Master 08 — Developer RFP / Intervention Test Build Specification and the Appendix — Technical Drawing Brief / Visual Architecture Reference v2. Master 08's own text and review-note states are unchanged by this addendum.